

INDIA'S DIGITAL LANDSCAPE: TAKING STOCK

How well has India wired its digital network, that aims to forge a new system of e-governance in the coming days

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In a country like India, where the problems hinge more on mindset and less on policy, digitisation has unanimously been dubbed as a very ambitious task. For years, India has had a familiar set of problems – poverty, illiteracy, sanitation, joblessness, etc.

Digitisation demands a basic level of digital literacy from people who might not even know how to read a word in their native language, even though almost all of them have cell phones in even the most remote areas.

The latest India Exclusion Report 2016 (IER) (<http://digit.in/ier2016>), suggests that despite the government's thrust towards digital in the country, it isn't producing the results we'd hoped for, mainly because of connectivity and infrastructure issues.

To list out the major highlights put forth by scholars and policy analysts in the IER report, it would suggest that the digital pathway of the country is faced with several roadblocks.

While the initiatives taken under the digital India initiative are laudable, bridging the digital divide is of vital importance, experts believe.

"One must keep in mind that roughly only a third of the country has access to the internet. Given the size of India's population, the infrastructure needed for digitisation of the country is woefully inadequate," says Shalini Narayan, Communications Advisor, Society for Promotion of Youth and Masses, a national organisation working towards community mobilisation, healthcare and socio-economic development.

DIGITAL INDIA

The IER 2016 suggests that the goals set during the launch of the Digital India initiative in July 2015, are nowhere close to be achieved. The plan to build the National Optic Fibre Network (NOFN) to provide broadband connectivity to 2,50,000 Gram Panchayats in three phases seems to have lost track now.

About 37 per cent of the network has been laid so far, and of the Gram Panchayats connected to NOFN, only 13 per cent have internet access. The report further adds that the government seems to have no clear direction to go with the NOFN and a continual tweaking of the deadline, is adding to the problem. Recently, the Union IT minister Ravi Shankar Prasad said that the entire target of connecting Gram Panchayats will be completed by mid-2018. If so, it would be a very successful project, given that even developed countries like Australia have struggled to build a fibre-optic backbone for the country in twice that time!

According to estimates, the cost of internet is a bit too expensive for at least 1.063 billion people in a population of 1.3 billion. Remember, we have over 25 per cent of rural India, and about 13 per cent of urban India living below the poverty line.

The digital locker facility, which lets people store their documents in the cloud, is a good concept and an efficient system, but is susceptible to cyber threats. Currently, loss due to documented cyberattacks stand over ₹25,000 crores in India.